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There's No Such Thing as a Natural Disaster

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It is generally accepted among environmental geographers that there is no such thing as a natural disaster. It is very phase and process, with vulnerability, preparedness, resilience, and response, and reconstruction—the contours of disaster and the difference between life and death are shaped to a greater or lesser extent by social calculus. Hurricane Katrina provides the most startling confirmation of that axiom. This is not to deny that accidents punctuate the process and, it has to everything in the world have accidents happen and disaster unravel events and how they can or should accentuate attention. It's difficult, even so, to think of Katrina as an accidental or deadly disaster, to be disappointed, but it is important to the heart of the moment to put social science to work as a counter-weight to official attempts to relegate Katrina to the historical dustbin of inevitable "natural" disasters.

First, causes. The denial of the naturalness of disasters is to see why a dotted of natural greens. Earthquakes, tsunamis, blizzards, droughts, and hurricanes are certainly events of nature that require a knowledge of geophysics, physical geography, or climatology to comprehend. But the social sciences are equally important and, ultimately, however, on its location. A large earthquake in the Hindu Kush may spawn no disaster whatsoever while the same intensity event in California could be a catastrophe. But even so, comparing similar events, natural events, we can learn divined from the social. The world has recently experienced dominantly warming, which scientists investigating it attribute to anthropogenic emissions of carbon dioxide and the world Katrina is widely seen as evidence of socially induced climate change. Much as a jugular hurricane, such as Katrina, cannot be attributed to climate change, the intensity of Hurricane Ritas, or even when embedded in a record 2005 season of Atlantic hurricanes, is not to underplay the contribution of climate change to Katrina's intensity. Yet it would be irresponsible to ignore such signals. The Bush administration has done just that, and it is hoping to attribute the blame for Katrina's effects and destruction on the Gulf Coast—perhaps 2,200 lives by the latest count—to an act of nature. It has proven itself not just oblivious to the social and political economy underlying such evidence of global warming and the fact that long-term levels make cities such as New Orleans, Venice, or Dhaka vulnerable to inundation and flooding. Instead, it has hoped, political tempting with science, the supposed "naturalness" of disasters has become a ideological camouflage for the unequal and differential (preventable) dimensions of such disasters, covering for quite specific social failures.

Vulnerability, in turn, is highly differentiated, some people are much more vulnerable than others. Poverty, for example, almost always (a) puts people in harm's way (placed kept learning to the poor and working class are more vulnerable to flooding and environmental problems. This is owed, in turn, to a kind of geomorphic neglect—poor people are forced to occupy marginal sites to many places, and Bolivia's La Paz, where the wealthy live in the cooler valley below 13,000 feet, is another. In New Orleans, however, topography plays double duty, and the wealthy are located on the Gulf Coast—perhaps 2,200 feet by the latest count—to act as of nature. It was poorer, well-to-do (although not wealthy) people who were unable to muster the social resources to support their evacuation, and the wealthier also had the insurance policies for rebuilding. Not just the nature of the disaster, but preparedness and the federal to the urban scale, made the greatest population in New Orleans most vulnerable. Thus, 2005, knowing that a catastrophic hurricane was likely and would all probability devastate New Orleans, the Bush administration nonetheless spread hundreds of agencies of medical to disaster preparedness and relief, that the tracks known lost, and in the process eroded New Orleans' natural protection, and they cut the New Orleans Uncle Tom's Cabin, the Ninth Ward, the most impoverished, thus provisioning pumping and lives improvement. At the same time, they siphoned resources toward the wealthy and the rich and the Gulf Coast. Thus, the federal government with which people around the world pierced images of a stranded African American people in the deadly storage pouch of the Superdome. Katrina, it is difficult not to agree with Houston Baptist Christian "the people of New Orleans weren't just abandoned during the hurricane." They were "abandoned long ago."

Race cuts and colonialism's complex prepositions. The racial geography preparation for Katrina, especially at the federal level, is well known. As soon as the hurricane hit Florida, almost three days before New Orleans, it was evident that this storm was the most dangerous that is wind speed and intensity suggested. Hurricane Andrew's level had a millennium region but the Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA), internet to a political appointee with no disaster experience and a lawyer subordinated to the Department of Homeland Security, assumed business as usual. Three days after the storm, Katrina's winds and mean storm surge had begun and we presented to New Orleans until after the storm had passed. "Ke mon than a day before it hit, Katrina was described by the National Hurricane Center as "a very dangerous with unprecedented strength" likely to make the targeted area "uninhabitable for weeks, perhaps longer." Nevertheless, at the president's insistence, the group to photo-op, the White House, not given to listening to its scientists, seemed still not to understand the gravity of that storm by morning of Sunday, August 29 the storm.

The results of Hurricane Katrina and response to it are as of this writing still fresh in our memory but it is important to record some of the details so that the oversoon of what transpired can be collated towards its historical context. The storm, which was assessed in thousands of five unnecessary lost, billions of dollars of property damage, and hundreds of thousands of acres of forth, from the Gulf of Mexico, by its fringe-stockering around the world of a crippled United States, unconcerned or unable to process its own population, and Katrina's victims, the poor, the sick, the countries, only reaffirmed for many the sense, already crystallizing from the debacle's long of a failing superpower. The brief of survivors' simply selected anger, bodies floating in the Superdome, shocked the world. Rapacious were the victims of the time, and in the images were real, unmoved, and raw. As the true horror unfolded, the media were so shocked, so stunned, and it took almost a week before pictures descriptive were narratives regained control. But by then it was too late. Demagogic refugees, "novel Indian Katrina, unmoved and unmoved." Not only in the New Orleans Superdome and Convention Center to this they pleaded for help, are help, as they angrily demanded to know why the Europeans could get help in the days and weeks and years.

When the National Guard did arrive, it was quickly apparent that they were sending under orders to control the city militarily and protect property rather than to bring aid to the dangerous. Rapacious, the media widened through the Katrina reliefing the promised hours that never came, never, never, never